ORBIS
the reading atlas

CULTURE

Which languages keep the record

A public figure can be careful and still stop at the border of the language it was released in.

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Closed books, blank paper and a lamp on an archive table. · AI-generated image

An official document released by the state is only as public as the borders of its language. From school guidance to census notes, any record published in a language not spoken in a city's homes is formally public but practically closed. UNESCO highlights this gap by noting that a large share of learners are not taught in a language they understand well. [1] Statistical databases suffer from the same bottleneck; for instance, while the UN Sustainable Development Goals database tries to keep indicators in more than one UN language, the depth of translation remains uneven. [2] The true width of a public claim is measured by the number of languages in which it can be opened and read.

Sources

1. UNESCO – Languages in education
https://www.unesco.org/en/languages-education

2. UN Statistics Division – Sustainable Development Goals
https://unstats.un.org/sdgs/